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African urban life: the transformation of Ouagadougou

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In contrast to the Catholic missionaries, they did not live in the center of town but in Gounghin, an area then fairly remote from the activities of the townspeople. Their decision to do so was as much a function of their concern for sanitation as it was a symbolic retreat from worldly affairs. Their comparative isolation was also conditioned by the fact that the American missionaries often were married couples, as much engaged in domestic activities as in religious work. Thus, unlike the Catholic missionaries, they could not have continuous face-to-face relations with their converts. Whereas the Catholic priests made a total commitment to their charges (mind, body, and soul), the American Protestants were interested only in their souls. The result was that few American Protestants developed that easy comradery or "joking" relationship with their African converts that one witnesses so often between the Catholic missionaries and their former students.

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Ouagadougou was the headquarters for the Assemblies of God in all parts of Mossi country, or, more exactly, all parts of the eastern Upper Volta. Actually, the mission there was more an administrative center than anything else. People did go there for conferences and reunions of converts, but the missionaries were fairly decentralized. The mission Bible school was located in Koubri, some 18 kilometers south of the capital, just as the Catholic seminary was located at Pabré, out in the country, but Koubri never gained the reputation for educational excellence as did Pabré. A number of young Protestant students left Koubri when they discovered that they were not getting the same education as were the Catholic boys [336](#) at Pabré. Later the protestants decided to build a regular school for Protestants at Sabin in the northern part of the town. This school received aid from the French Protestants and from the government and has started to graduate students

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with the B.E.P.C. It is also serving to attract children who would otherwise not have the opportunity to receive an education in the overcrowded Catholic and private schools. As is to be expected, the Protestants are recruiting converts from this school.

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